

June 30, 2026

Dear Selection Committee,

I am writing to express my interest in the Summer School on Socioeconomic Opportunity and Inequality at Universidad Icesi. I am a PhD student in Economics at the University of Chicago working at the intersection of labor, development, political economy, and economic history, with a current project on how high schools shape college choices in Chile. The program's focus on inequality dynamics, social mobility, and state-of-the-art methods is closely aligned with the questions driving my research: how institutions, information, and educational environments shape opportunity, and how those mechanisms operate in highly unequal Latin American settings.

My current paper, "Do High Schools Shape College Choices? Evidence from Centralized Assignment in Chile," uses the Chilean centralized high-school assignment system to study whether the school a student attends changes later higher-education decisions. I link assignment records with administrative data on school enrollment, standardized achievement, higher-education applications, and enrollment, and use lottery variation in school offers to examine the causal role of high schools in shaping STEM enrollment and the quality of postsecondary institutions students attend. The results suggest that high schools affect students through channels that are not captured by achievement value added alone. Choices that look like revealed preferences can partly reflect information, expectations, preparation, and local peer or institutional environments. This is, at its core, a question about opportunity: why students with similar initial conditions can end up facing different paths through the education system.

The summer school would be especially valuable at this stage of my work because it brings together the substantive and methodological conversations that I most want my dissertation to engage. Sessions on the geography of social mobility in developing countries, trajectory-based approaches to measuring intergenerational mobility, econometric tools for evaluating mobility, and meritocracy speak directly to the empirical and conceptual issues I face in interpreting school assignment and later-life educational choices. The broader discussions on inequality, structural change, redistribution, and long-run development in Latin America would also help me situate my project within regional histories of exclusion, institutional capacity, and uneven access to opportunity.

My interest in Latin America is both personal and intellectual. I am Chilean, but much of my formal economics training has taken place in the United States. That position has made me especially aware of the value of building research relationships with scholars based in the region, and of understanding regional data, institutions, and policy debates from the inside rather than at a distance. Before beginning my PhD, I worked as a research professional for Professor Christopher Blattman on projects involving gang governance in Colombia, violence reduction in Liberia, and comparative political economy. I also worked with ConsiliumBots, an education research data lab connected to Chile, where I helped manage a nationwide randomized evaluation of information and personalized feedback in college application behavior and built tools for monitoring implementation with the Chilean Ministry of

Education. These experiences pushed me toward research that is empirically rigorous but grounded in the institutional details that make policy questions real.

I would also bring to the summer school a deep interest in education as a central mechanism of inequality. My earlier undergraduate research studied Chilean grants for doctoral training, and my current work asks how secondary schools shape students' higher-education trajectories. Across these projects, I have become interested in how education systems convert family background, geography, school quality, and access to information into later opportunities. In Latin America, where educational expansion has often coexisted with strong stratification, these questions seem especially urgent. I hope to contribute to conversations about how empirical evidence can inform policies that expand mobility without reducing students and families to narrow measures of achievement.

Finally, I am excited by the format of the summer school itself. The opportunity to present early-stage research, receive feedback from senior researchers, and learn alongside advanced students, policy professionals, and early-career scholars would be enormously valuable as I refine my dissertation agenda. I would be particularly grateful for the chance to engage with scholars working in and on Latin America, and to build lasting intellectual relationships that can continue beyond the meeting in Cali.

Thank you for considering my application. I would be honored to participate in the Summer School on Socioeconomic Opportunity and Inequality and to contribute to its conversations on education, mobility, and inequality in the Americas.

Sincerely,

Bruno Aravena-Magüida